



Historic: Defending champion RSPB completed a hat-trick of titles.

Pics: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

brothers Mumtazur Rahim and Arif Rahim, who both played football and hockey for the Maharashtra Police side. The Orange City is not particularly known for producing hockey talent, and the brothers had to look elsewhere to build a career in the sport.

"There is no infrastructure in Nagpur. There are no astroturfs or even grass turfs for us to play on. Whoever wants to play the game has to move outside," Sayyad told *Sportstar*.

After playing hockey through the junior levels in Nagpur, Sayyad joined the Sports Authority of India (SAI) Regional Centre in Mumbai from 2007 to 2010, which paved the way for him to join the Railways, where he has been playing since.

Sayyad's career path also opened the door for his younger brother, who promptly joined SAI Mumbai and found his way into the Navy, where he has spent more than eight years.

The two brothers have also come close to international call-ups, honing their skills at national team camps. Sayyad was part of the national probables before the

COVID-19-induced break ahead of the Tokyo Olympics. Aakib, on the other hand, is fresh off participating in a 54-member National Coaching Camp under head coach Craig Fulton, held in Bengaluru in April.

"I got to learn a lot in that one week. I understood where my weaknesses are and what I should work on," Aakib said.

"The way we trained was entirely different. What we do on a day-to-day basis is enough for domestic hockey but not for the international level," he added.

Aakib was also part of the Hyderabad Toofans squad for the Hockey India League in 2024 and, despite not playing a single game, says he gained abundant knowledge from international stars Gonzalo Peillat (Germany) and Arthur de Sloover (Belgium).

Sayyad hopes his performances this season can help him secure a place in the franchise-based league, alongside Aakib and his fiancée, Priyanka Wankhede, who plays for the Shrachi Rarh Bengal Tigers.

"The HIL is an important tournament for the players. You have the money and the fame, but you are also being watched live by the Indian seniors and selectors. The auction will be in December. I hope someone shows interest," Sayyad said.

FINAL

INDIAN RAILWAYS

3

Shivam Anand 8', Pankaj Rawat 37', Sayyad Niyaz Rahim 57'

NAVY

1

Aakib Rahim Arif 15'

